

SIGNAL

Transit Fiction — A New Trilogy
The Transit Trilogy · Book One



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BOOK FOUR

SIGNAL IN URANUS

in co-authorship with Claude (Anthropic)

*"I was transmitting a signal into the void.
It turns out someone was tuned to my frequency."*
2888. Planet Earth. A continuation of Protocol Λ.

How to read this book

The text of this book exists in four registers at once.

The main narrative — what is happening. Ordinary type, full line.

[Square brackets — Arthur's inner voice. For the reader only.]

{ Curly braces — Melissa's inner voice. Arthur does not see it. }

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// MONOSPACE BLOCK – fragments of the Grid. // Arthur sees the world as an  
architecture of data. // This is not a metaphor. For him it is real.
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*I was transmitting a signal into the void.
It turns out someone was tuned to my frequency.
I didn't know about it.
It changes nothing. It changes everything.
— Arthur, draft entry, 2888*

*I was observing the one who observes.
In the end I stopped understanding which of us was the object of study.
— Melissa, final entry*

PART I PRESENCE

Chapter 1. The Man in the Corner Chair

The library. Morning. 2888.

Nora had worked in this library for forty years. In forty years she had learned one thing: every person who enters carries a question within them. Sometimes the question knows its owner. Sometimes — not.

Arthur came in at 9:14. He always came at 9:14 — not deliberately, Nora had checked. His morning route simply produced exactly that time. He took the corner chair, took *The Physics of Space-Time*, and opened it to page 44.

[Pages 44–67. The chapter on observers who alter the observed. I've been reading it for seven years now. Each time — different. Not because the text changes. Because I change.]

Nora watched him over the catalogue. With him she caught herself each time thinking: he reads not in order to learn. He reads in order to remember.

Nora sets before him a book he did not request.

NORA: *The Theory of Observers*, the 2074 edition. You've read one passage in the physics of space-time many times. Pages 44–67. It's about observers. I thought — you need more.

[She knows. For forty years she's watched what people read. But librarians don't usually bring the sequel without a request.]

ARTHUR: Have you seen many like me?

A long pause. Nora sits down across from him — the first time in forty years.

NORA: No. Like you — no.

[She said it without pity and without surprise. As a fact.]

Chapter 2. Melissa's First Entry

The same library. The same day. Two hours later.

Melissa came to the library for another reason — she needed an article on the biology of adaptation. Arthur sat in the corner. She noticed him before she saw him.

{ This is not a metaphor. I'm a biologist. I know I have no organs for measuring the pressure in a room. But something had changed. }

The article on adaptation stayed untouched. Melissa opened a new file and wrote:
"Entry No. 1. The man in the corner chair."

{ He reads pages 44–67. The same passage. Not from failing to understand — his face is calm. As if there's something there that needs to be kept close. Like a photograph. }

Chapter 3. Alex and Coffee

A café across from the library. The next morning.

ALEX: You're strange today.

[Today. As if yesterday I was different. He doesn't understand that I'm always like this.]

ARTHUR: I'm always like this.

ALEX: No. Today you look at the people in the café as if you're counting them.

[Twenty-three people. Fourteen — in screens. Six talking, but listening only to themselves. Two — truly here. Eight point seven percent presence at a meeting place.]

{ Alex says "strange" — but that's not the word. Arthur isn't strange. He's a different angle. The same light, a different angle of incidence. }

ARTHUR: About how you all put up with it.

ALEX: Put up with what?

{ Arthur went silent. It's the silence of a man who has just opened a door — and decided not to go in. }

ARTHUR: Never mind. How are you?

Alex talked about work. Arthur listened. Melissa was writing. None of the three knew they were already inside one story.

PART II TRANSMISSIONS

Chapter 4. Arthur's First Transmission

// TRANSMISSION No. 1 // Status: active // Recipient: unknown // Frequency: unknown

The sun shone here again today. They call this the norm.

I watch how they react to the light. They don't react. They're used to it. They walk beneath the sun without lifting their faces. I lift mine every time. It isn't dignity. It's design. I'm made differently.

[This is the first time I write about it directly, without the polite translation. That's already something.]

Chapter 5. Melissa's Entry. On Language

{ Today I'm thinking about language. Arthur speaks normally. But sometimes, in the middle of a sentence, he makes a pause — as if translating. Not searching for a word. Translating, exactly. From something else. }

NORA: He's been coming since 2881.

{ Seven years. He's been coming here for seven years. }

NORA: Once. He asked whether we had anything about how the stars look from another star. I said: no. We don't have that angle of view yet. He said: "A pity. I remember how they look, but I can't check."

{ I don't know what that means. But I know it was the truth, not an image. }

Chapter 6. Daniel and the Anomaly

DANIEL: I think you're an anomaly in the system.

[An anomaly — data that doesn't fit the current model. It means the model is incomplete. An anomaly is more valuable than the norm.]

DANIEL: I build systems for people. My models don't work with you. You're unpredictable.

ARTHUR: That's bad for your systems.

DANIEL: It's good for me. An anomaly is the place where a system can grow.

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// GRID FRAGMENT No. 3 // Daniel: node of type builder_local // The  
difference: Daniel builds. Arthur observes.
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Chapter 7. Oma at the Harbor

{ They were alike. Two people looking at the horizon with the same expression. Not longing. Not waiting. Simply — looking. }

OMA: I've sailed everywhere. And everywhere people look at the sea the same way. As if they're waiting. No one knows for what.

ARTHUR: And do you know?

OMA: I know you don't have to wait. You can just look. That means something too.

[The first simple and precise description of what I've been doing all this time. I'm not waiting. I'm looking.]

{ I want to know what Oma said. I will never ask. }

Chapter 8. Sati and the Direct Question

SATI: You're not from here, are you?

She didn't wait for an answer. She walked on.

*[Not "you're different." Not "something's wrong with you." Just: not from here.
Like a coordinate, not a diagnosis.]*

*{ Sati said aloud what I'd been writing in brackets. The first time anyone said it
openly. And wasn't afraid. }*

PART III THE POINT OF INTERSECTION

Chapter 9. The Party at Daniel's. Rina.

RINA: It isn't a pathology. It's a stance. They held on to what they see — not to who they are. A very stable construction. And a very lonely one.

{ A stance. I underlined the word. Not an illness. Not a peculiarity. A stance. }

Chapter 10. Leo Writes an Article

LEO: I write about people who live as if they're outside their own lives.

[Outside their own lives. No. I'm outside yours. That's different.]

ARTHUR: I'm not outside my life. I'm outside yours.

LEO: I began this article three months ago. Now I understand: I'm describing myself.

[This is his moment — when you say it aloud and hear it for the first time.]

Chapter 11. Rain. Alex.

ALEX: Have you ever wanted to just... disappear? Not to die. Just — to stop being here?

[Stop.]

[He just said the thing I feel every day. He's — local. And he wants to disappear. And I want to disappear because I never got here in the first place.]

[We want the same thing. From different places. It's the same exhaustion. God. It's the same exhaustion.]

ARTHUR: Yes. Almost every day.

ARTHUR: I write.

ALEX: Us?

[No. Myself. You I use as a surface. But it's exactly in conversations with you that I understand what I think.]

ARTHUR: You too. But mostly — myself.

ALEX: Honest.

[Yes. For the first time in a very long while — honest.]

PART IV THE SIGNAL IS FOUND

Chapter 12. That Very Night. Two Voices.

The rain did not stop. Arthur came home and sat down to write. Melissa came home and opened her notebook. They did not know of each other. They were writing about the same thing.

Arthur:

I understood today why I write.

Not because I want to be understood. I write because it's the only way not to lose myself in translation.

I've been translating myself into words for a very long time. Something is always lost. It isn't a tragedy — it's physics.

But today Alex said: do you want to disappear from here? And I understood that he translates too. We're both translators in a world that thinks it speaks one language.

That's enough to keep transmitting the signal.

Melissa:

I sit and write this at two in the morning. Beyond the window — rain.

He changed my instruments without knowing it. That's the strongest influence — when you're changed by someone with no intention of changing you.

Arthur transmits a signal into the void. That's what he thinks. But I'm here. I read him. I write it down.

The signal has found a recipient. He just doesn't know it yet.

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// FINAL STATUS · BOOK ONE // Arthur: signal active. Direction unknown. //
Melissa: signal received. Arthur does not know. // Next: Book II · THE
RECEIVER
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* * *

— END OF BOOK FOUR —

— SIGNAL —

BOOK FIVE · THE RECEIVER · FOLLOWS